

“Please go to the land above the sea and find me a monkey who will give me its liver,” the Dragon King said.

The jellyfish set off to the surface, where it found a monkey sitting on a rock, throwing stones into the water. He tempted the monkey into the sea by promising to show him the coral palace. On the way there, the monkey asked the jellyfish why he had been chosen to visit the majestic palace.



The jellyfish, who had always lived under the water, had never learned to tell lies, so told the monkey the truth.

“The Dragon King needs your liver to heal his wound.”

Unlike the jellyfish, the monkey, who had lived on land among the humans, had learned how to lie. “I wish you had told me that before,” he said to the jellyfish, “I would have brought it with me. I keep it in a jar in the tree where I live, as it is too heavy for me to carry with me.”

“Swim me back to the surface and wait for me by the shore,” the monkey said. “I will fetch my liver and bring it right back.”

Trustingly, the jellyfish led the monkey back to the beach and watched him run off into the woods. After waiting patiently for two days and two nights, the jellyfish realized with great sadness he had been tricked, and he knew he must return to tell the Dragon King.

As the jellyfish swam closer to the palace, its heart grew heavier and heavier.

Ryujin was furious. “Please don’t punish me,” said the jellyfish, “I have already been tricked by the monkey I trusted, there’s no need for me to be punished twice.”

But the Dragon King was too angry and in too much pain from his wound to listen. He used his great powers to curse the jellyfish.

“You will swim the seas forever without a shell” he roared in fury.

And so, the jellyfish became the jellylike creature it is to this day. They say that the jellyfish’s sting comes from the bitterness it felt at being punished twice, just for trying to help.

